

Love Armed



POEM TEXT

1 Love in Fantastic Triumph sat,
 2 Whilst Bleeding Hearts around him flowed,
 3 For whom Fresh pains he did Create,
 4 And strange Tyrannic power he showed;
 5 From thy Bright Eyes he took his fire,
 6 Which round about, in sport he hurled;
 7 But 'twas from mine he took desire
 8 Enough to undo the Amorous World.

 9 From me he took his sighs and tears,
 10 From thee his Pride and Cruelty;
 11 From me his Languishments and Fears,
 12 And every Killing Dart from thee;
 13 Thus thou and I, the God have armed,
 14 And set him up a Deity;
 15 But my poor Heart alone is harmed,
 16 Whilst thine the Victor is, and free.

Abdelazer) [personifies](#) Love as a triumphant warlord gloating among the "Bleeding Hearts" of the people he's struck down. Love has beauty and might: he's "armed" with the passionate "fire" that springs from a lover's "Bright Eyes," and with his infamous "Killing Dart" (that is, his arrow, which readers might recognize from the popular image of Cupid shooting his bow). As the master of "desire," Love has strength "enough to undo the Amorous World"—to lay waste to a whole world full of desperate lovers.

Those who fall under Love's power, the speaker warns, will suffer from "Languishments and Fears"—heart-stopping helplessness and anxious terror—and bow before Love's "Pride and Cruelty," his unstoppable and merciless ability to do his own will. Love, in other words, does exactly what it wants to. It doesn't respond to reason, and it's as likely to leave a person totally miserable as rapturously happy.

This vision of love as a tyrant does away with sentimental images of Love as rose petals and daydreams. If Love makes the world go round, this poem suggests, he does so by conquering it like a tyrannical emperor. (Even the image of love sitting in "Fantastic Triumph" calls up an ancient Roman festival of bloodshed: a "triumph" could mean a ceremonial procession to honor a military victory.)



SUMMARY

Love sat in fantastical, glorious victory while broken hearts oozed blood around him. He devised more and more new tortures for those hearts, displaying his awful, merciless power. He took the fires he carelessly threw around straight from your brilliant eyes. But it was from my eyes that he took his stores of longing—enough of it to destroy a whole world of lovers.

He took his sad sighs and weeping from me; he took his cruelty and pride from you. He took helplessness and terror from me, and he took his deadly arrows from you. So you see, between us, you and I have given Love all his weapons and made him into a god. But in the end, it's only my heart that has been hurt. Yours is the winner, and it's untouched.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-14



THE PAIN OF UNREQUITED LOVE

Besides painting a portrait of love as a tyrannical god-king, this poem laments the pain of a specific kind of love: the unrequited variety. The speaker is terribly in love with someone who doesn't feel the same way about them (at least, not any more). They imagine that the conqueror Love takes his destructive powers from the feelings they and their beloved have toward each other, and is thus "armed" with two very different sets of skills.

From the beloved, for instance, Love takes its "Pride and Cruelty," its arrogant mercilessness. This line suggests at once that Love itself is unkind in forcing lovers to fall for people who don't love them back—and that the speaker's beloved has unkindly turned them away, discarding them as if they were trash. Similarly, Love takes its passionate "fire" from the beloved's "Bright Eyes," a [metaphor](#) in which the beloved's beautiful gaze can only burn the poor speaker to a crisp.

The unfortunate *speaker's* eyes, meanwhile, give Love "desire / Enough to undo the Amorous World." That is, the way they look at their beloved reflects a yearning so great that it could lay



THEMES



THE TYRANNICAL POWER OF LOVE

In "Love Armed," the mighty "Deity" of Love isn't some sweet little Cupid bopping around with pink-tipped arrows. Rather, he's a cruel tyrant, a world-conqueror who mercilessly crushes hearts underfoot. The speaker of this poem (which opens the first scene of Aphra Behn's play

waste to an entire world full of heartsore lovers. They also have to endure "Languishments and Fears," helplessness and anxieties, endlessly suffering over their beloved's refusal; these sufferings, too, are part of Love's arsenal.

The different kinds of weapons that Love takes from the speaker and the beloved set up a picture of love, not just as a merciless and powerful force, but as a horribly *uneven* one. As the speaker puts it, "my poor Heart alone is harmed" once Love has put on its armor and picked up its weapons: the beloved, with their "Bright Eyes" and their "Pride and Cruelty," has all the power in this relationship. Love is terrible and powerful at the best of times, the [extended metaphor](#) of arms and armor suggests. But it's most terrible when it's shared out unequally.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 5-16



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*Love in Fantastic Triumph sat,
Whilst Bleeding Hearts around him flowed,
For whom Fresh pains he did Create,
And strange Tyrannic power he showed;*

"Love Armed" opens Aphra Behn's 1676 play *Abdelazer*, a dark tale of lust and vengeance. As the play begins, the title character—a prisoner in the Spanish court—is sitting in a "rich chamber," an elegant room, listening to this song. In other words, "Love Armed" sets a scene. A gory and alarming scene it is, too.

As the poem begins, Love is [personified](#) as a "Tyrannic," cruel warlord. He sits in "Fantastic Triumph"—a turn of phrase that here doesn't so much mean "amazing triumph" as "fantastical, almost surreal triumph," as if the poem is gazing into the speaker's nightmare. (The word "triumph" might even suggest Love looks something like a Roman emperor in all his glory: a "triumph" was originally a splendorous parade celebrating a Roman military victory.)

And Love does appear to have conquered all—but not in the way we'd usually say so. In his fantastic triumph, he looks out over a field of "Bleeding Hearts," his conquests: [metaphorically](#) speaking, all the unfortunate souls who have suffered (and perhaps even died) for love.

Readers here might think of the traditional image of Love as Cupid or Eros, the Greco-Roman god who shoots arrows into the hearts of unsuspecting civilians and sends them head over heels. But this version of Love isn't satisfied simply to make people fall inconveniently in love. He's a downright sadist, dreaming up "Fresh pains" with which to torment his fallen

victims and reveling in his "strange Tyrannic power."

This song, then, will be a hellish vision of Love as a tormentor and a destroyer. Aphra Behn frames her grisly images in a simple form:

- The poem is built from two eight-line stanzas of [iambic](#) tetrameter. That means that each line uses four iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "For **whom** | Fresh **pains** | he **did** | create."
- Behn does sometimes break from that rhythm, though. For instance, the first line begins with a bold [trochee](#), the opposite foot to an iamb (with a DUM-da rhythm): "Love in | fan **tas-** | tic **Tri-** | umph sat." Love enters the poem with a bang!
- The singsongy rhymes run ABABCDCE EFEGFGFE. In other words, the poem uses a pattern of alternating rhyme, strengthening it in the second stanza with that persistent, echoing F rhyme. Keep an eye out for that pattern as it develops: the poem's mood intensifies just as the rhyme does.

LINES 5-8

*From thy Bright Eyes he took his fire,
Which round about, in sport he hurled;
But 'twas from mine he took desire
Enough to undo the Amorous World.*

The poem's speaker has just finished introducing the nightmarish figure of Love triumphing over his fallen victims and their "Bleeding Hearts." Now, a new character enters the scene: the speaker's beloved, whom the speaker addresses directly. Love, the speaker says, got one of his cruel weapons straight from the beloved's beautiful body:

From thy Bright Eyes he took his fire,
Which round about, in sport he hurled;

The beloved's eyes are so bright they seem to burn. (The intense long /i/ [assonance](#) of "From thy Bright **Eyes** he took his fire" evokes that flaming energy.) And, [metaphorically](#) speaking, these eyes give Love a nasty toy to play with: spears of passionate fire, like thunderbolts. Love throws these dangerous weapons around "in sport," casually, not caring whom he sizzles. The speaker, readers begin to gather, might have fallen into the path of these fires.

The speaker's own eyes have given Love a weapon, too: "desire." There's enough desire in the poor speaker's gaze to "undo the Amorous World," the speaker says; in other words, the longing in the speaker's eyes could lay waste to a whole world full of lovers, like Love's own weapon of mass destruction. Desire, then, is a terribly dangerous thing.

Readers might already see the problem here. Just as the

poem's title promises, Love is being "Armed," given weapons and armor. But the *kinds* of weapons he takes from the speaker and the beloved are very different. The beloved is the bright-eyed desired, the speaker is the helpless desirer; the beloved, readers can guess, does not love the speaker back. Though each of the pair gives Love some of his tools, those tools are mismatched. This can't end well.

LINES 9-12

*From me he took his sighs and tears,
From thee his Pride and Cruelty;
From me his Languishments and Fears,
And every Killing Dart from thee;*

Lines 8-11 deepen the [extended metaphor](#) of Love taking his weapons from the speaker and their beloved. Just as readers might have begun to suspect, the poor speaker gives Love all of his sorrowful powers—"sighs and tears," "Languishments and Fears"—while the beloved gives Love his "Pride and Cruelty," his arrogant and sadistic impulses to treat poor mortals just as he pleases. And while the image of Love taking his "Killing Dart" from the beloved raises classical pictures of Cupid and his quiver of heart-tipped arrows, it also suggests [metaphorical](#) darts: cruel words, scornful glances.

Love, in this vision, is *nothing* but trouble. The speaker doesn't mention Love's pleasures and joys at all; they might as well not exist. This perspective clearly has a lot to do with the fact that the *beloved* is all "Pride and Cruelty," that their heart is hardened against the speaker's "sighs and tears."

The very structure of these lines emphasizes how painfully mismatched the beloved and the speaker are:

*From me he took his sighs and tears,
From thee his Pride and Cruelty;
From me his Languishments and Fears,
And every Killing Dart from thee;*

The [repetition](#) here plays the beloved and the speaker off each other in a pained [juxtaposition](#). Both parties arm love—but while the beloved gives Love his powerful and indifferent qualities, the speaker only contributes "Languishments" (sickly weaknesses) and pains.

LINES 13-16

*Thus thou and I, the God have armed,
And set him up a Deity;
But my poor Heart alone is harmed,
Whilst thine the Victor is, and free.*

As the speaker moves into their closing lines, they spell out what they've implied all along: between them, the speaker and the beloved have given Love his power to hurt and destroy, making him into a mighty and merciless "Deity."

Readers might hear a climax coming in the poem's music. This is

the moment when the [rhyme scheme](#) intensifies: rather than choosing a new rhyme for lines 14 and 16, Behn sticks to the same sounds she used in lines 10 and 12, so that "Cruelty," "thee," "Deity," and "free" link up into a relentless chain.

These closing lines capture the speaker's terrible predicament. Though the speaker and their beloved have played an equal part in arming Love, they don't get equal treatment from him. As the speaker puts it:

[...] my poor Heart alone is harmed,
Whilst thine the Victor is, and free.

In some sense, then, the beloved has *sided* with cruel Love, becoming his sadistic ally rather than his pitiful, bleeding-hearted victim. The speaker reproaches their beloved and Love itself in one swoop.

They also indulge in more than a little self-pity. *All* the suffering is theirs, *all* the cruelty their beloved's; woe is them!

Readers might pity the poor speaker too, though. Love truly has been cruel to them. The sad [alliterative](#) music of "my poor Heart alone is harmed" suggests a kind of inevitability to this predicament, a sense that harm was baked into this "poor Heart" right from the beginning. No mortal heart could ever stand up to a being of such "Tyrannic power" as Love has proven to be.



POETIC DEVICES

PERSONIFICATION

The speaker's [personification](#) of Love portrays a classical love god—Cupid or Eros—as a terrible warlord, a vision that captures love's power to hurt and destroy.

Modern-day readers may be more familiar with an image of Cupid as a cherub with a quiver of heart-tipped arrows, but he was once imagined as an adult man (or, most often, a beautiful winged youth). Here, he turns into something more like a Roman emperor, a tyrant sitting in "Fantastic Triumph." The word "triumph" might even suggest he's enjoying a parade in his honor: in ancient Rome, a "triumph" was a ceremonial procession celebrating a military victory.

This triumph is a particularly gory one. Love sits among all the "Bleeding Hearts" he's laid waste to, gloating, relishing his "strange Tyrannic power" over the whole "Amorous World." This is not the [serene, beautiful Eros of classical art](#), or even the popular image of a [mischievous trickster](#) causing trouble among foolish mortals. This is a vision of Love as a monstrous, sadistic dictator.

In personifying Love this way, the speaker is getting a dig in at their merciless beloved as much as they're making a broader point about the pains of romance. After all, Love takes much of

his [metaphorical](#) armor—like his “Pride and Cruelty”—straight from the proud, cruel beloved.

Where Personification appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-14

EXTENDED METAPHOR

In tandem with the [personification](#) of Love as a tyrannical emperor, the poem uses an [extended metaphor](#) to imagine how Love works its nefarious deeds. Love is “Armed,” given his weapons and armor, by the speaker and their beloved, whose tragically different feelings show that Love’s destructive power is greatest when he torments one person more than another.

The beloved’s “Bright Eyes,” for instance, provide Love with the [metaphorical](#) “fire” of passion. In other words, a mere glance from the beloved makes the speaker feel like they’re burning up with desire and longing. Love uses this fire as a weapon, playfully “hurl[ing]” it around “in sport,” caring not a bit how much destruction he causes. In just the same way, readers gather, does the beloved use their bright eyes.

The beloved also arms Love with his “Killing Dart.” This metaphor summons up the traditional image of Cupid with his arrows, inflicting love on unsuspecting civilians. Here, it also hints at the beloved’s rejection of the speaker, perhaps through “Killing,” stinging words that shoot straight through the speaker’s heart. Here, passion and cruelty kill at the same moment and the same way.

Thus armed, Love leaves a trail of “Bleeding Hearts” behind him—a metaphor for romantic pain so old that it might at first hardly even register as a metaphor. Here, though, the speaker brings the [cliché](#) to gory life again: love really does seem to wound them.

Where Extended Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** “Bleeding Hearts around him flowed,”
- **Lines 5-6:** “From thy Bright Eyes he took his fire, / Which round about, in sport he hurled;”
- **Line 12:** “And every Killing Dart from thee;”

ASSONANCE

“Love Armed” was originally set to music. But even without its tune, the poem feels musical: [assonance](#) makes the lines chime and ring.

Rather than interweaving different flavors of assonance, Behn often sets up long chains of the same vowel sound. For instance, listen to lines 3-4:

For whom Fresh pains he did Create,
And strange Tyrannic power he showed;

All those long /ay/ sounds give force to this description of Love’s sadistic cruelty.

There’s an even more intense string of echoing vowel sounds in line 5:

From thy Bright Eyes he took his fire,

The long /eye/ sound there feels as piercing as the fiery glance of the beloved’s eyes. The music of this line might evoke the speaker’s longing for the *beauty* of those “Bright Eyes” as much as the fiery pain their glance gives. The same sound recurs a moment later in line 7 when the speaker sighs, “’twas from mine he took desire”—a line that matches the speaker’s eyes to the beloved’s through *sound* while emphasizing the terrible distance between the kinds of looks the speaker and the beloved exchange.

Perhaps the poem’s most poignant moment of assonance (and [alliteration](#), for that matter) appears in line 15:

But my poor Heart alone is harmed,

The echoing /har/ sound here makes the harm to the speaker’s heart seem as if it were built into it from the start, almost a foregone conclusion.

Where Assonance appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** “pains,” “Create”
- **Line 4:** “strange”
- **Line 5:** “thy Bright Eyes,” “fire”
- **Line 6:** “round about”
- **Line 7:** “mine,” “desire”
- **Line 9:** “sighs”
- **Line 10:** “Pride”
- **Line 15:** “Heart,” “harmed”

REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) underscore the terrible *imbalance* between the speaker and their beloved: all the love is on one side of the scales, here.

Both the speaker and their beloved have given Love the arms and armor he needs to destroy a whole “Amorous World” of lovers. As the speaker puts it:

From me he took his sighs and tears,
From thee his Pride and Cruelty;
From me his Languishments and Fears,
And every Killing Dart from thee;

These [parallel](#) phrases suggest that the speaker and the beloved have both played their part here. Even the echoing internal rhyme between “me” and “thee” tightens the

[juxtaposition](#).

But of course, there's a big and terrible difference between the weapons the speaker and the beloved have given to Love. The speaker arms Love with the sufferings that Love inflicts on people unlucky in romance: "sighs and tears," "Languishments and Fears." The beloved arms Love with more powerful weapons: the "Pride and Cruelty" that make Love such a tyrant, the "Killing Dart" with which he strikes lovers down.

Through these repetitions, then, the speaker makes the point that Love doesn't deal fairly. The beloved and the speaker are both *involved* with Love, but only one of them is suffering.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 9:** "From me"
- **Line 10:** "From thee"
- **Line 11:** "From me"
- **Line 12:** "from thee"

**VOCABULARY**

Love (Line 1) - Love here is [personified](#) as Cupid or Eros, the classical love god. Here the speaker seems to be imagining him in his more imposing adult form, not as a winged cherub.

Fantastic (Line 1) - Here, "fantastic" means something like "fantastical"; the speaker is describing the kind of vision of Love one might see in a dream.

Tyrannic (Line 4) - Cruel and all-powerful (like a tyrant, a merciless absolute ruler).

Thee, Thou, Thy, Thine (Line 5, Line 10, Line 12, Line 13, Line 16) - Old-fashioned ways of saying "you" and "your":

- "Thee" is the object form of "you," as in "I love thee"
- "Thou" is the subject form of you, as in "Thou hast wounded me"
- "Thy" means "your"
- "Thine" means "your," and is usually used before a word that starts with a vowel (as we use "an" before a word that starts with a vowel rather than "a"). Here the speaker uses "thine" because they're referring to their beloved's "heart," which would have been pronounced with a dropped "h."

"Thee" and "Thou" work rather like *tu* in modern-day Spanish, French, and Italian: they're the more informal, familiar way of saying "you," and suggest that the speaker is talking to someone they know intimately.

In sport (Line 6) - Playfully, carelessly.

Hurled (Line 6) - Threw, flung.

'Twas (Line 7) - A contraction of "it was."

Undo (Line 8) - Destroy, lay waste to.

Amorous (Line 8) - Lovestruck.

Languishments (Line 11) - Weaknesses, ailments. The word suggests that the speaker has been totally ruined by love: the reader can imagine that the speaker can't do anything but lie around and groan.

Killing Dart (Line 12) - Murderous arrow. An [allusion](#) to Cupid's arrows.

Set him up a Deity (Line 14) - That is, made him into a powerful god.

**FORM, METER, & RHYME****FORM**

"Love Armed" is the song that opens Aphra Behn's play *Abdelazer*, a tale of love and treachery. This little ditty is what Abdelazer himself is listening to as the play begins; a captive in the Spanish court, he's brooding over his forbidden lust for the Queen of Spain. The poem sets the tone for the stories of sex and violence that follow.

The poem's 16 lines are written in [iambic](#) tetrameter (lines of four iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "From me | he took | his sighs | and tears") and divided into two eight-line stanzas. This simple form is meant to clue the play's watchers into the poem's themes right away, inviting them into a world in which love is a conqueror and a destroyer.

METER

"Love Armed" is written in [iambic](#) tetrameter. That means it uses lines of four iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in line 15:

But my | poor Heart | alone | is harmed,

These iambs lend the poem a steady, driving heartbeat. But Behn often varies that rhythm to give this little song flavor. For instance, the very first line plays with meter:

Love in | Fantas- | tic Tri- | umph sat,

The first foot there is a [trochee](#)—the opposite of an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm. That strong stress up front introduces the "Tyrannic" figure of Love with a bang. Small variations like this appear throughout the poem to add interest and emphasis.

RHYME SCHEME

The [rhyme scheme](#) in the first stanza of "Love Armed" runs as follows:

ABABCD CD

This simple, singsongy alternating rhyme scheme suits a poem meant to be sung. In the second stanza, though, the speaker intensifies that pattern. The poem still uses alternating rhymes,

but it drills down hard into one rhyme in particular:

EFEFGFGF

The insistent return to the F rhyme ("Cruetly," "thee," "Deity," "free") in the second stanza subtly turns up the heat under the speaker's declaration of heartbroken despair.

While modern-day readers might hear a [slant rhyme](#) in the pairing of "sat" and "Create" in lines 1 and 3, listeners in Behn's time would have heard a perfect rhyme: the word "sat" was once pronounced (and often spelled) *sate*.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is a heartbroken lover. Imagining Love as a "Tyrannic" king relishing his "Triumph" over the world, the speaker details how this warrior god was equipped. His beauty, strength, and terrible cruelty he got from the speaker's beloved. His ability to strike people down with "languishments" (frailties) and desperate "desire" he took from the unfortunate speaker. The implication is that the speaker has all the painful longing, the beloved all the cruel rejection. This is a speaker who has come to know Love all too well as a merciless god.

It's not clear whether the beloved once loved the speaker back, or whether this is a case of fully unrequited love. Either way, it hardly matters: the speaker is suffering as terribly as if their "Bleeding Heart[]" were oozing at the love-god's feet.



SETTING

There's no clear setting within the poem beyond a "Fantastic" (or fantastical) dreamworld in which the cruel, beautiful god of Love sits in triumph, enthroned like a Roman emperor after a victory on the battlefield. This vision presents Love as a merciless but splendid warlord, a guy one can neither resist nor tear one's eyes away from.

There is a setting *around* the world of this poem, though. This song opens Aphra Behn's play *Abdelazer*, a tale of lust and vengeance. The title character (a prisoner in the court of the King of Spain) is listening to this song in what the stage directions call a "Rich Chamber," an elegantly appointed room in the palace. Such a setting hints that material can't console a frustrated lover any more than it can console a prisoner. Perhaps unrequited love and imprisonment even have a few things in common!



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Aphra Behn (1640-1689) was one of the most striking and enigmatic writers of the English Restoration (the 17th-century

period during which King Charles II was restored to the throne after the rebellious "Lord Protector" Oliver Cromwell died). Renowned as the first woman to make a living through her pen, Behn was famous in her day as a writer and a public figure. Nonetheless, much of her life story remains a mystery.

There are no records of Behn's exact date and place of birth (though she was certainly British), and things only get murkier from there. Some believe Behn herself obscured or destroyed records of her life to preserve her aura of mystery. All we can gather of Behn's early life is that she may have lived for a time in the European sugar colony of Suriname, South America (perhaps as a spy for King Charles II), and was reportedly married to a man named Johan Behn, who died or separated from her sometime around 1664.

Upon her return to England, Behn had little money. She took up writing in order to stay out of debtor's prison, producing poems, plays, and novels. A woman writer making her own living, she was groundbreaking in more ways than one. Not only was she one of the first English novelists, she also treated subjects that were then thought to be far outside a woman's grasp. For instance, her novel [Oroonoko](#) (arguably her most famous work) tells the story of an enslaved African prince who rises to courtly power by dint of his brilliance and inherent nobility. It became an important text in early arguments against the slave trade.

Behn was also an active part of London's theatrical world and a noted playwright. Through the theater, she became friends with other Restoration writers like [John Dryden](#) (as well as more scandalous figures like the notorious [John Wilmot, Earl of Rochester](#)). This poem comes from her popular 1676 play *Abdelazer*, a sensational tale of murder and lust set in the Spanish court.

Behn's artistic legacy influences writers to this day, and she's often heralded as an early feminist hero. As no lesser writer than [Virginia Woolf](#) said in her famous essay "[A Room of One's Own](#)": "All women together ought to let flowers fall upon the tomb of Aphra Behn [...] for it was she who earned them the right to speak their minds."

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Aphra Behn was one of the most important writers of the Restoration: that is, the wild, fun-loving, and often debauched era that followed King Charles II's return to the English throne in 1660. Charles had been in exile since 1649, when the Puritan rebel Oliver Cromwell overthrew—and beheaded—Charles II's father, King Charles I. But the intensely moralistic government Cromwell installed in the place of the monarchy was neither popular nor stable, and it didn't take long for the country to welcome its exiled king-in-waiting back.

When Charles II took the throne, he ushered in a new era of freedom and pleasure. Cromwell, a severe Puritan, had cracked down on art, holidays, and fun in general. The canny Charles

realized that one way to win his people's affections was to encourage all the pleasures that Cromwell had outlawed. His court was full of poets and artists—and also full of new opportunities for unusual figures like Aphra Behn, who may even have served as Charles's spy at one point. Theater in particular (strictly verboten under Cromwell) saw a creative boom under Charles, and Behn's plays stand alongside those of satirical writers like [William Wycherley](#) and [William Congreve](#) as exemplars of Restoration drama.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about the strange and wonderful life of Aphra Behn, the poem's groundbreaking author. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/aphra-behn>)
- [Abdelazer](#) — Examine an early printing of Abdelazer, the play in which this song appears. (https://www.google.com/books/edition/Abdelazer_or_The_Moor_s_revenge_a_traged/Y11iAAAacAAJ?hl=en&gbpv=1&pg=PP1&printsec=frontcover)
- [Behn's Legacy](#) — Read a recent appreciation of Behn that

argues she should be a more widely known and celebrated figure in English literature. (<https://lithub.com/the-first-english-woman-to-make-a-living-as-a-writer-was-also-a-spy/>)

- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a dramatic reading of the poem. (<https://youtu.be/Ezu5IVCP4AE?si=2UvtngM5LWn6bceG>)
- [A Portrait of Behn](#) — See a posthumous engraving depicting Behn. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/portrait/mw15592/Aphra-Behn>)



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